

House centipede *Scutigera coleoptrata*

Centipedes

Class Chilopoda

Species 3,149

Occurrence Humid habitats on land

Unlike an insect, which has a three-part body and three pairs of legs, a centipede's body is made up of a long chain of similar segments, each equipped with a pair of legs. Some centipedes have more than 150 pairs. The front legs are modified into venomous claws that curve around the head for seizing prey such as worms and snails; large tropical centipedes can even catch and devour frogs, lizards, and nestling birds.

Millipedes

Class Diplopoda

Species 9,973

Occurrence Humid habitats on land

Similar to centipedes, but almost exclusively vegetarian, millipedes have two pairs of legs on each body segment. As a result, some have as many as 375 pairs of legs, or 750 in total. Despite this, they move much more slowly than centipedes, creeping along on rippling waves of leg movement. They avoid predation by coiling into tight armored balls, depending on length, or rely on glands that secrete toxic chemicals, including cyanide.

Maxillopods

Class Maxillopoda

Species 17,987

Occurrence Oceans, fresh water, hot springs, land

This group of crustaceans is largely made up of copepods and barnacles. Copepods swarm in the plankton of oceans and fresh waters worldwide; they are mostly very small, and feed on drifting algae. Barnacles are also planktonic when young, but then settle on rocks, where they grow a protective armor of hard shell plates. Common on tidal shores, they close up at low tide, but extend feathery limbs to gather drifting food particles when submerged.

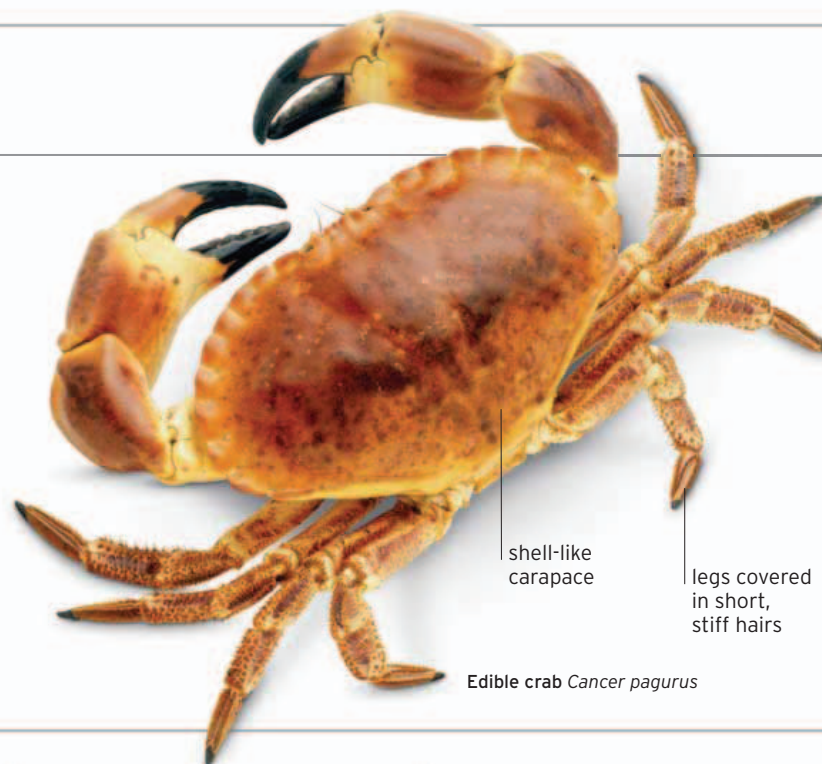
Malacostracans

Class Malacostraca

Species 38,032

Occurrence Marine intertidal to abyssal zones, freshwater habitats

The largest class of crustaceans, this includes shrimp, crabs, lobsters, and crayfish, as well as less familiar forms such as krill, sandhoppers, and terrestrial woodlice. Many swim in open water, while others live on the seabed or on tidal shores. Some, such as most shrimp and prawns, are delicate, almost transparent, but the crabs and lobsters are heavily armored, with stout pincers for feeding and defense.

Edible crab *Cancer pagurus*

Sea spiders

Class Pycnogonida

Species About 1,330

Occurrence Coastal areas to deep oceans

Despite their name, sea spiders are not spiders (or even arachnids). A sea spider appears to be entirely composed of four or more pairs of legs, joined at the center. However, it does have a small cylindrical body and an even smaller head with four eyes and a sharp proboscis, flanked by a pair of palps and a pair of feeding claws. It uses these to prey on marine animals such as corals and sponges, tearing off pieces with its claws or simply stabbing into them and sucking their juices.

Horseshoe crabs

Class Merostomata

Species 4

Occurrence Shallow waters

Despite their name, these marine animals are not true crabs. They are distantly related to arachnids, such as spiders, but look quite different because of their body, which is covered by a broad, hinged shield, or carapace, with a long spinelike tail. Beneath the carapace are five pairs of legs and a pair of pincerlike chelicerae, which the crab uses to seize and cut up prey, such as clams, as it plows through the soft sediments of the seabed.

Scorpions

Order Scorpiones

Species 1,500

Occurrence Mainly deserts, forests

Scorpions are relatives of spiders, with eight legs, but instead of subduing their prey with venomous fangs as spiders do, scorpions have a stinger on the end of a long tail. The tail can arch forward over the body to sting and paralyze prey, but typically a scorpion prefers to seize its victims with its powerful pincers and tear them apart. The sting is more useful for defense, and the venom of some species is powerful enough to kill an adult human.

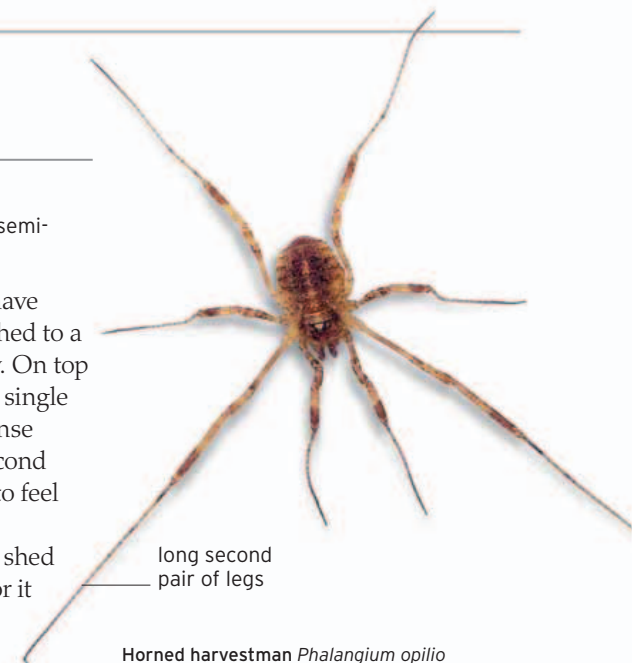
Harvestmen

Order Opiliones

Species 6,125

Occurrence Mainly grasslands, semi-deserts, forests

The spiderlike harvestmen have very long, slender legs, attached to a small, almost spherical body. On top of the body is a turret with a single pair of eyes, but the main sense organs are the extra-long second pair of legs, which are used to feel for prey and edible scraps. If attacked, a harvestman may shed one or more legs to escape, or it may spray its attacker with noxious fluid.

Horned harvestman *Phalangium opilio*